and under the constant fire of the Rajput soldiers, deep trenches were dug with mud walls to shelter the workers. Even so, casualties on the Mughal side were bruising, and 100–200 labourers a day were killed by snipers. Akbar rewarded the survivors so handsomely that people exclaimed that the worth of silver and gold had reduced to dust. Thousands of men and animals were employed in these tasks, with many tons of ration and fodder required. Mughal access to the heartland and resources meant that as Rajput rations dwindled over the winter months inside the fortress, Mughal supplies and men kept arriving.

For the soldiers within the fortress, the earlier mood of confidence and elation would have progressively slid into bemusement, and then a sort of horror, as they saw the very landscape outside Chittor moulting and morphing into something monstrous: in every direction were the tunnels and mounds of earth leading inexorably towards the fort, like a disarticulated beast, unstoppable even after they had pounded them with cannons and fired all their musket rounds; there would have been elephants trumpeting impatiently in the distance, hauling cannon, daggers strapped to their tusks; dust rising from the artillery shots; men, armies of them, inexhaustible, straining at ropes and scaffolding as they built siege towers and sabats; and high towers studding the siege perimeters, from which officers surveyed the work; archers in full armour, wheeling on their pure-blood horses, were shooting arrows in every direction. The horses themselves looked like beasts from a nightmare, entirely covered in plates of armour, even their heads, their braided manes pulled through openings in their neck armour. Rumbling through the air would have been the ominous, syncopated rhythm of many drummers, each signalling the presence of a high-ranking Mughal officer. Most shocking of all were the siege guns, monsters which could fire projectiles weighing more than a ton. But there were also smaller, more manoeuvrable ones, including cannons large enough for half-maund balls which Akbar had cast on the battlefield itself, in his presence, to avoid having to drag the larger ones forward. And the noise would have been incessant, a weapon in itself, the relentless whine and thud of cannon shots and muskets, and the whistling of arrows.

On 17 December, two mines were laid against the walls of Chittor and set off, but they misfired and, in a deafening explosion of stone and dust and blood, the storming party itself was blown up, some 200 men, while 40 Rajputs were killed. Akbar constantly patrolled his frontline, as cannon